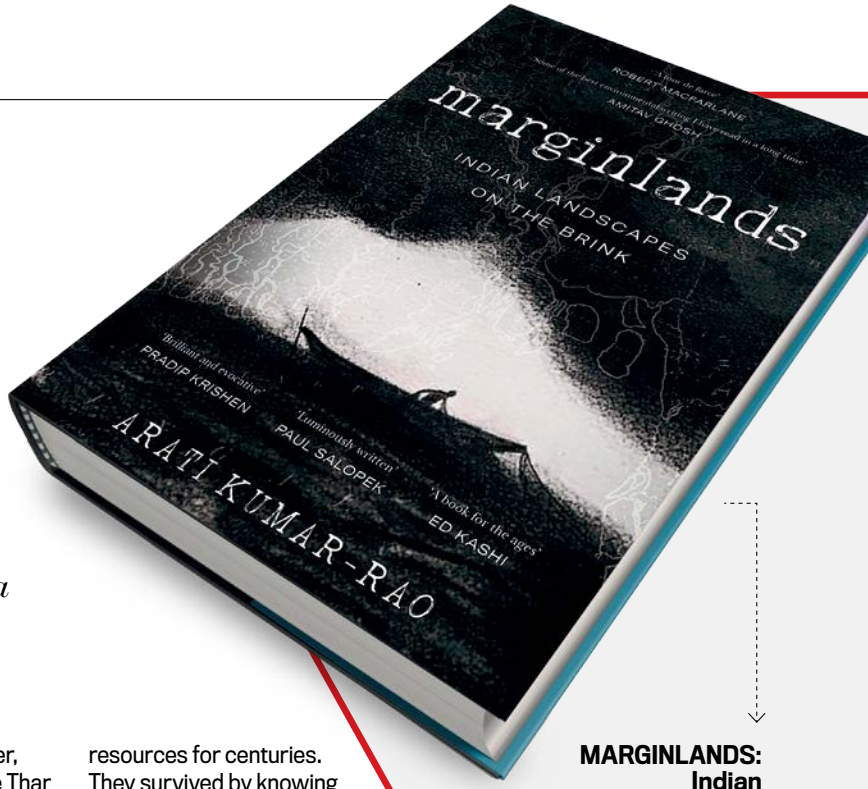
BOOKS

Reading the Land

Arati Kumar-Rao's *Marginlands* *is a timely chronicle of India's changing landscapes and climate*



MARGINLANDS: Indian Landscapes on the Brink
by Arati Kumar-Rao
PICADOR INDIA
Rs 699; 264 pages

You might say that this is the right time to read a book like Arati Kumar-Rao's *Marginlands*, as our forest regulations are being diluted, our hillsides are collapsing under the weight of rain and greed, and our coasts are crumbling into the sea. But the misguided policies arising from the misreading of landscapes began centuries ago. And as long as an official sees a mountain and calculates how many cubic metres of granite can be mined from it, or looks at a riverbed and plans to build a runway there, those misguided policies will live on.

In each chapter of her book, Kumar-Rao maps expansively, and probes intensively, a precisely balanced and highly fragile ecosystem and the people who have lived with it. Then she narrates the history of policies and developments that are killing it. She writes of the secret stores of water, and prosperity, in the Thar Desert, which looks empty to those with no eyes to see. It has no forests, no wildlife of the type that fits on a logo, and the government labels it a wasteland. So it mines the landscape, installs windmills, and lays roads that block a delicate network of aquifers and wells, till the desert actually becomes a wasteland. Along the western coast of the subcontinent, stone seawalls, groynes and concrete breakwaters disturb the natural flows and accretions of sand and have alarmingly speeded up erosion instead of mitigating it.

The mangroves of the Sundarbans, the ever-shifting silt islands of the Ganga and Brahmaputra, the glaciers of Ladakh, and Mumbai's intertidal zone all have similar tales to tell. In her prologue, Kumar-Rao says she took a year to explore and understand the Thar Desert. A year to dismantle a writer's urban certainties and begin to glimpse the complex play of rain, sand, wind, and the humans who have husbanded scarce resources for centuries. They survived by knowing how to read the land, and the impact of what is called development has been hardest on them.

If we were to look away from the violence done to these landscapes and their inhabitants, we would only see the same violence reported in the newspapers. But *Marginlands* also offers hope. In Ladakh, an engineer and educator of the region developed a way to build ice stupas, in effect artificial glaciers, at particular altitudes so that they would melt and supply water as needed for crops and vegetation on the lower slopes. "Why should we take these changes lying down?" he asks. That question lifts the reader's heart, and we will no doubt find answers where we should have looked for them in the first place. It should not be left to the sufferers of climate upheavals to find solutions. But we will all suffer sooner or later from those upheavals, and we too, Kumar-Rao imagines, may learn to read the land. ■

Latha Anantharaman

BOOKS

PAWS FOR THOUGHT

Vivek Menon's new, improved field guide to Indian mammals is an essential companion to conservation awareness